

Who's looking at you?

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In the 15 years since government funds first became available for public CCTV, the UK has evolved to be the most surveilled country in the world. It has more surveillance CCTVs than anywhere else on Earth. Even as long ago as 2002, according to researchers, the average UK city dweller, going about their ordinary business, is caught on camera more than a hundred times a day.

So enthusiastically has the UK embraced public space surveillance that this small island is now home to 20 per cent of the world's CCTV cameras. Huge sums of money have been spent, and over 600 of the UK's towns and cities now deploy CCTV cameras on their streets. And, though accurate figures are hard to come by, best estimates suggest there is now one CCTV camera for every 14 citizens – an

As India considers significantly stepping up its use of CCTV surveillance as part of increased security measures in the wake of the Mumbai attacks, we ask: will CCTV work? The UK has more CCTV cameras than anywhere else on earth and it's now the world's most heavily surveilled society. We look at the benefits and lessons that can be learnt from the UK CCTV experience

astonishing 4.2 million lenses pointing at the population.

CCTV is now a routine and accepted part of British daily life. It is omnipresent. It's in every major public space, at every transport hub, inside every shop and office, in schools, stadiums, colleges and hospitals, it covers every major highway and every major public event.

Does CCTV work?

So what's been learnt in these 15 years of public scrutiny? Has CCTV increased public protection?

Well, the short answer is that CCTV is proving a very useful and valuable tool for a whole range of different applications – except for the one thing it was originally installed to achieve: crime prevention.

All of the research conducted thus far, and there have been several academic studies, indicates that CCTV's power to deter (or displace crime to areas without CCTV) – just through the fact of its being there – is quite limited. It can have a deterrent effect on a few specific types of crime (for example, car crime in controlled areas such as multi-story car parks). But



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